Last Plea

By Mark Bellusci

INTRODUCTION

Do you swear to tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth so help you God? You'd better. You don't have much of an option anymore. Lying isn't going to do you any good; the jury's practically convicted you anyway. This is the one chance you have left. Make it good.
"Last Plea" by Mark Bellusci

When he is brought up on charges for stalking his estranged wife, Tony makes the following plea to the judge.

TONY: Your Honor, I know you heard all the testimony and everything. And I know I've done some wrong here, there's no doubt about it. But, you know, before you go and, uh, think it all through, I just want to try and explain my side of the story-no, I know my lawyer did that-and he did a damned-sorry, your honor-a darned good job of it. But-and no offense to your court or anything-it was all kind of legalese stuff. I just want to explain it the way it really happened. You know, in plain English.

(Beat.) No no no, it won't take more than a minute or two. *(Beat.)* Okay, so where do I-I don't know, I guess we started having troubles a couple a years ago. Right after we had the kid, but before we- *(Beat.)*
Okay, Your Honor. I was just setting up why what happened, but-okay, so we're having troubles after the kid. Nothing big at first, regular arguments like all my buddies have with their wives. But for some reason, ours just got worse. Got so bad I didn't wanna come home a lot of nights-

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and sometimes I didn't. I mean, with the nagging and the kid crying and me trying to just get a little peace after a hard day's work-you're a guy, your Honor, you know. *(Beat.)*

Well, then you're the lucky one, Your Honor, cause most guys I know, they know what I'm talking about 'cause they've been there. But anyway, it keeps getting worse and worse-the yelling and the screaming and everything. And I'm cutting outta there more and more-just to avoid getting in fights with her. Well, one day, I come home after staying out all night, and she's got this look like a psycho killer. She's quiet at first, but then she starts hitting me-hitting me! Me, who never touched her in her life, she is hitting. And she's not stopping! She's whacking me! So after a while-and I'm a patient guy, I took some shots, my wife, you've seen her, she's built like a middle linebacker-after a while I gotta defend myself. *(Beat.)*

No your Honor, I never hit her. No sir! I just kept my hands up and tried to hold her off. I mean, if you saw us after the battle, I'm the one with the black eyes and shi-and stuff. She just had a couple a bruises on her arms where I held her. *(Beat.)*

That's exactly what I'm leading up to, your Honor. So after this little battle royale, after she beats the shi-the heck-outta me, she says *she's* moving out. You believe it? I get whacked around and *she* can't take it no more. So that's what she does she ups and leaves, with the kid. Well Your Honor, I gotta be honest with ya, at first I felt great. I mean, really

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great. All the pressure off. No kid yelling and screaming, no woman nagging at me. It was like the old single days. But see, here's where it gets fuh-messed-up. See, as happy as I was when she left, I started getting miserable again. Like, all of a sudden, the house was too quiet. Actually missed the kid screaming-I even missed Julia's nagging. I mean, Your Honor, first she makes my life miserable by being home, then she makes my life even more miserable by *not* being home. I mean, we're supposed to be married, we're supposed to work through all that shi-stuff, right? And that's what I went over her house to tell her. *(Beat.)*

Yeah, I'm almost there, your Honor. Just another minute. So anyway, I go to her mother's house, tell her I'm sorry for our troubles and that she could come home. And you know what? She says she ain't coming home. Says I'm not ready for her to come home. Me? The one who got beat up? I'm not ready? So, naturally, I get a little pissed. Who wouldn't? I tell her I'm her husband and she's got to come home. So she boots me. Boots me! Her husband! Threw me out on my as-butt. And every time I come over after that, she don't even answer the door. But see, I'm not about to give up on our marriage that easy. I figure, If I could just talk to her-reason with her a little bit-she'll see the mistake she's making. So what I would do is just drive over and wait for her to come out. You know, just so I could talk to- *(Beat.)*

Yeah, your Honor, I know. But, see, I still can't figure out how that could be stalking if all I want to do is talk to her- *(Beat.)*

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You're right, that's a done deal. We plead on that-but still okay, never mind. So anyway, what happened after, that's what this whole thing is about anyway, and that's what I wanted to talk about. It was about a month ago. I was out earlier that night, at this club, La Mouche-hey, she's living the good life at her mothers, I might as well have a little fun too. So I'm talking to some young girl. She wants to dance, I dance with her. She wants to drink, I buy her drinks. She wants to giggle with her little girl friends about me being older, I just put on a dumb smile and deal with it. Next thing I know, we're in her car, grabbing and mauling, grabbing and mauling, and I'm into it-I mean, your Honor, I am a man with needs and everything. So I'm into it with this young girl whose name I don't even know, just like the old single days, you know? Then, outta the blue, I start thinking about Julia.

Julia! Even when she's not there, she's there. Pissing me off, interfering where she's got no right to interfere. And me? I'm losing it with this hot, drunk twenty-one year old. So that's it, I decide. I tell this girl I'm not into it, she's too stoned to care, and I leave. So...I decide I can't enjoy fuh-messing-around, getting drunk, stoned anymore; might as well live with her. *(Beat.)*

No, it's not exactly a romantic way to put it, but that's the way I felt. And I wanted her to know, right then and there. So, I drive to her mother's house. Now I admit, it was late. But all I figured on doing was staying in the car, right in front of her house, be there as soon as she

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comes out in the morning for work. But then I get to thinking, it's hot and miserable in my goddamned car, why the hell do I have to sleep like a dog when she's in a comfortable bed. So I rang the bell. Told her I needed to speak to her. And you know what? She never even opened the door! Told me I'd better leave or she was calling the cops. And she did! She called the fuh-the frigging cops on her husband! *(He sighs.)* Well, I was gonna sit there in my car, let them take me in, you know? But, then I'm thinking, frickin' cops, why should their life be so easy when mine's a mess? They wanna get in the middle of my marriage, I'll make 'em work for their paycheck, those fat, lazy Irish bastards- *(Beat.)*

Sorry, your Honor. I didn't know you were part Irish. So-and I now know this was wrong, your Honor-I tear ass outta there. And the cops, they take off right after me. Next thing I know, I'm in a high-speed chase, just like the movies! Well, we're going pretty good, sixty on the side roads. Let me tell you, those guys stayed right with me. So there I am, going through the side streets, you know? But now there are more and more cops on my ass, so I figure, before they cut me off completely, I'll get on the highway, really open it up. So I get on the Belt, figuring if I could make it over the Verazano bridge and through Staten Island, I'll be in Jersey and the cops can't touch me. But when I got on the Verazano Bridge there were, like, thirty cop cars waiting there for me. So that's it, I pullover and I'm ready to go in peacefully. By that point I was tired of the whole thing. So, when I get outta the car, I got my hands on my head, like they do on TV, and I'm just standing there. Well this one cop who's

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supposed to put the cuffs on me-I'll never forget his name-O'Reilly, that Irish bastard. Sorry your Honor. He comes up to me and starts pushing me, calling me a piece of garbage, saying he wishes he could just beat me till I'm senseless. Well I know my rights. I don't have to sit there taking that from some cop. So I yelled back at him. And then-I don't know, it depends on how you interpret it-I kinda may have pushed him, I think. See, he was so close to my face, with his bad breath and all. I just wanted a little breathing room. Problem is-and everything was happening so fast, you know-I may have instinctively, like, put out my hands, you know? Just to get that breathing room. And, well, when I put my hands out-I don't know-my fists, well, they couldda been closed. And I think that, well, um, my closed hands, they were, like, near his face. So,

I don't know, I guess to some of them, from their angle, it could have looked like I was punching him in the face-which I wasn't, technically. But I think the Irish bastard cop-sorry your Honor I think he thought I punched him, because he went down like he was shot. *(Beat.)*

No, your Honor. Absolutely not! I did not deck him! See, his face kind of lunged forward right into my closed hands, which were just trying to get me a little breathing room. *(Beat.)*

Yeah, your Honor, that's what happened. The way it really happened, no matter what the cops say. So okay, now you know the story, I'm happy. And to be honest with you, your Honor, I kinda don't care at this point

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what you decide, because, I'm already in jail. Solitary confinement in my head, constantly thinking, "how did I fuh-mess-it up so bad?" My wife, my kid, my family, her family, they pleaded, they yelled, and now they're done with me. I'm alone here, your Honor. With my brain racing all the time and me stuck in neutral, running outta gas. *(Beat.)*

Yeah, that's it, your Honor. You do what you got to do. I appreciate your letting me take a little time here. And I hope I helped clear up a few things. Thanks. Thanks a lot.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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